● PROJECT 3 OF 20

# How to Talk About This Project in an Interview

FMCG distribution analytics is tested in interviews for sales strategy, category management, distribution planning, and general business analytics roles. This guide teaches you how to frame the Bharat Foods case for any of those audiences — from the 60-second opener to handling the hardest challenge questions.

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|---|---|
| **Project** | Project 3 — Bhārat Foods Q2 FY2026 FMCG Distribution Review |
| **Domain** | FMCG Distribution · Channel Mix · Category Management · Distributor Health |
| **Tools used** | Excel — cross-sheet VLOOKUP/SUMIFS, pivot tables, custom scoring model |
| **Key skills** | Distribution analytics · Scheme ROI · Sec/Primary ratio · Investment modelling |
| **Roles it fits** | Sales Strategy Analyst · Category Analyst · Distribution Planner · General BA |
| **Unique angle** | Health Foods 81.6% growth is actually a warning sign — the most counter-intuitive insight in the curriculum |

**The one insight that makes this case memorable**

Health Foods grew +81.6%. Most students — and many interviewers — will assume that's good news. Your answer: 'Actually, it's a warning signal. Return rate is 31.6%, scheme cost is 19.8% of sales, and net scheme ROI is 3.46x — below the 5x launch benchmark. My Q5 recommendation was zero incremental investment in Health Foods.' That counter-intuitive insight is what makes this case memorable in any interview.

## What's in this guide

## 01 · The 10 Numbers You Must Know Cold

These 10 numbers need to be in your head before you walk in. Know both the value and the why — an interviewer will always ask the follow-up.

| # | Metric | Value | Why it matters in an interview |
|---|---|---|---|
| **1** | Total primary sales | ₹120.1 Cr | Sets the scale of the business immediately |
| **2** | GT+MT growth rate | +28.6% | 4× faster than GT-only — the channel strategy insight |
| **3** | GT+MT avg per distributor | ₹16.6L | 13% premium over GT-only — quantifies the MT advantage |
| **4** | Health Foods growth | +81.6% | Sounds great — the counter-intuitive punchline follows |
| **5** | Health Foods return rate | 31.6% | The number that changes everything — nearly 1 in 3 units returned |
| **6** | Health Foods scheme ROI | 3.46x | Below 5x benchmark — the investment decision pivot |
| **7** | Beverages growth | −7.7% | Category in decline — anchor for the Beverages story |
| **8** | Tamil Nadu Bev. Sec/Primary | 0.07 | Weak consumer pull — unforgettable as a specific number |
| **9** | Tier 2+3 penetration | 0.9% | In a ₹5,321 Cr market — the whitespace opportunity |
| **10** | % distributors not visited 60+d | 28.1% | Network quality signal — feeds directly into Q5 allocation |

**◆ The bonus number that impresses interviewers**

Tier 2+3 market size = ₹5,321 Cr vs current Bharat Foods Tier 2+3 sales = ₹46.6 Cr. That's 0.9% penetration. Every 0.1% penetration gain = ₹5.3 Cr revenue. It reframes the ₹15 Cr Tier 2 investment from 'cost' to 'growth bet with measurable ROI.' Pairing the penetration % with the market size is the move most candidates miss.

## 02 · The 60-Second Project Introduction

### ★ The script

**Context (10 sec):** 'I worked on an FMCG distribution analytics case for Bharat Foods — a mid-cap Indian consumer goods company. 800 distributors, ₹120 Cr in primary sales, and ₹40 Cr of capital to deploy in Q3.' **The problem (10 sec):** 'The CMD's question: where does the ₹40 Cr go to maximise Q3 growth? The real decisions beneath that: which channels, tiers, and categories are actually healthy, and which distributors are dragging the network.' **What I did (15 sec):** 'I built three cross-sheet joins — primary sales to distributor data, trade schemes to primary sales, and returns to primary sales. The scheme join was the critical one: it let me compute scheme ROI per category.' **What I found (25 sec):** 'Health Foods looked like the star — +81.6% growth. But once I netted out 31.6% returns and 19.8% scheme cost, scheme ROI was 3.46x — below the 5x benchmark for a new category launch. Meanwhile, GT+MT distributors were growing 4× faster than GT-only, and Tier 2+3 was only 0.9% penetrated in a ₹5,321 Cr market. So the ₹40 Cr went to Tier 2 expansion and GT+MT conversion — not Health Foods. Health Foods got zero incremental spend until returns are fixed.'

### ◆ Why the Health Foods pivot is your best opening asset

The sequence matters: start with what looks true (81.6% growth), then reveal what's actually true (3.46x ROI below benchmark). That structure — surface finding, then deeper finding that flips the recommendation — is exactly how senior analysts think. It demonstrates that you didn't stop at the first number.

### ▲ The most common mistake in the opener

Listing findings without a throughline. Don't say: 'GT+MT grew more, Tier 2 penetration is low, Health Foods has high returns, Beverages is declining.' Instead: 'The data pointed in one clear direction: three structural growth levers (GT+MT, Tier 2, Biscuits/Snacks) and two problems to fix (Health Foods returns, Beverages pull). The ₹40 Cr allocation flows directly from those findings.' One story, not five bullets.

## 03 · The PRISM Walkthrough

When asked 'walk me through your analytical process,' reach for PRISM. FMCG distribution tests the same five-step discipline as marketing or CRM analytics.

**P**

### Problem Definition

The CMD's question is 'where does ₹40 Cr go?' But the real decisions are: (1) which channels and tiers have the most untapped potential, (2) which categories are genuinely healthy vs promo-propped, (3) which distributors are dragging the network, and (4) how do we allocate capital against those findings. I restated the question as: 'What combination of channel, tier, category, and distributor investment delivers the highest risk-adjusted incremental revenue in Q3?'

**What this signals to the interviewer:** You distinguish the question asked from the decision behind it.

**R**

### Reframe

Five sub-questions: (1) GT+MT vs GT-only — is Modern Trade access a growth driver? (2) Which city tiers have whitespace relative to market size? (3) For each category: is growth organic or scheme-driven? What are the net returns? (4) Which distributors are underperforming — and can I score them? (5) Given 1-4, allocate ₹40 Cr.

**What this signals to the interviewer:** You decompose before touching the data.

**I**

### Investigate

Three cross-sheet joins were critical. Primary_Sales → Distributors (adds city_tier, channel_type). Trade_Schemes → Primary_Sales (adds scheme cost per category). Returns → Primary_Sales (computes return rate). The scheme join is the most important: without it, Health Foods looks like the star. With it, scheme ROI = 3.46x — below the 5x launch benchmark. **That single join changed the entire investment recommendation.**

**What this signals to the interviewer:** You join before concluding. You know which schemas connect.

**S**

### Solve

Six cuts: channel × growth, tier × growth × penetration, category × growth/returns/scheme ROI, distributor × sales/overdue/visits/returns, state × Sec/Primary ratio, SKU × contribution. **Health Foods' 81.6% growth collapsed to a weak business under decomposition. Tier 2+3 whitespace only appeared when I computed 0.9% penetration against ₹5,321 Cr market size.** Both findings are invisible in the aggregate.

**What this signals to the interviewer:** You decompose before concluding. Every key finding came from a cut.

M

### Measure

Two capstone deliverables: (1) Distributor Health Score — weighted six-feature scorecard, Critical/Watch/Healthy tiers, reason strings for the top 50 at-risk. (2) ₹40 Cr Investment Model — every allocation grounded in a specific Q1-Q4 finding, with quantified expected returns. CMD gets the growth strategy. CFO gets the ROI math. Sales Head gets the distributor action list.

**What this signals to the interviewer:** You close the loop — Q4 findings feed Q5 allocation.

## 04 · The 12 Most Common Follow-up Questions

After your opener, the interviewer probes. Here are the 12 questions that come up most in FMCG and distribution analytics interviews, with model answers.

### Q1.

**[ Domain fundamentals — FMCG vocabulary ]**

Q: *What is primary sales vs secondary sales and why does the ratio matter?*

**A:** Primary sales is the sell-in: Bharat Foods billing to distributors. Secondary sales is the sell-out: distributors selling to retailers. The Sec/Primary ratio measures actual consumer demand pull vs trade push. A ratio of 0.07 in Tamil Nadu Beverages means only ₹7 of every ₹100 pushed to distributors is selling through to consumers. That's not a demand problem — it's a distribution quality problem. The stock is piling up at distributors without moving to retail.

### Q2.

**[ Counter-intuitive insight depth ]**

Q: *Why is Health Foods your most important finding — and why does 81.6% growth concern you?*

**A:** Because 81.6% growth driven by scheme spending and followed by 31.6% returns is not genuine category growth — it's inventory pushing. The scheme cost is ₹1.27 Cr on ₹6.42 Cr gross sales (19.8%). After netting returns, net sales are ₹4.39 Cr. Net scheme ROI = 3.46x. The benchmark for a new category launch is 5x+. The growth looks impressive because the denominator is small and the scheme spend is large. If we remove schemes, the category likely shrinks. That's a dependency, not a success.

### Q3.

**[ Technical execution — cross-sheet joins ]**

Q: *How did you compute scheme ROI — walk me through it exactly.*

**A:** Three steps. First, join Trade_Schemes to Primary_Sales on category — I used SUMIFS to get total scheme cost for Health Foods: ₹1.27 Cr. Second, compute net sales: gross primary sales ₹6.42 Cr minus returns ₹2.03 Cr = ₹4.39 Cr. Third, divide: ₹4.39 Cr / ₹1.27 Cr = 3.46x. The benchmark of 5x comes from the Benchmarks sheet in the dataset. Without joining Trade_Schemes, you can't compute this — and Health Foods looks like an unambiguous winner.

## Q4.

**[ Investment sizing logic — quantified ]**

*Q: Why did you allocate ₹15 Cr to Tier 2 expansion specifically?*

**A:** Because the data shows Tier 2+3 is 0.9% penetrated in a ₹5,321 Cr total market. At 0.9% penetration with +19.8% and +27.5% growth rates in Tier 2 and 3, the market is clearly accessible — we're growing fast where we're entering. Every 0.1% penetration gain = ₹5.3 Cr additional revenue. Moving from 0.9% to 1.5% penetration = +₹32 Cr incremental. The ₹15 Cr covers distributor appointments, working capital support, and trade activation for approximately 80 new Tier 2 distributor additions.

## Q5.

**[ Model building + validation thinking ]**

Q: *What is a distributor health score and how would you validate it?*

**A:** A weighted scorecard across six features: average monthly sales (25%), payment overdue days (22%), last ASM visit days ago (18%), return rate (17%), months active in the 6-month period (10%), and tenure years (8%). Each feature is normalised to 0-100 via percentile rank — directionally adjusted so that high sales = high score but high overdue = low score. Composite = weighted sum. Validation: check whether the Critical-tier distributors (<40) have higher actual dropout rates or revenue decline in the next quarter compared to Healthy-tier. A good score predicts future outcomes — not just describes current ones.

## Q6.

**[ Industry context — benchmark to larger players ]**

Q: *How is Bharat Foods different from a company like HUL or ITC in terms of distribution?*

**A:** Scale and depth. HUL and ITC have direct coverage of 3-4 million outlets; Bharat Foods with 800 distributors reaches a fraction of that. The GT+MT split also matters: large FMCG players have dedicated Modern Trade teams and direct billing to MT chains, while Bharat Foods routes all sales through distributors. The implication: Bharat Foods' growth lever is network expansion and GT+MT channel addition, not the brand-level marketing plays that HUL uses. Different instruments for different stages of scale.

## Q7.

**[ Leading indicator thinking — SEC/PRIM as signal ]**

Q: *Why is Tamil Nadu Sec/Primary = 0.07 for Beverages alarming?*

**A:** Because it means almost no consumer sell-through. The normal range for a functioning Beverages distribution is 0.20-0.35 — for every ₹100 pushed to distributors, ₹20-35 should sell through to consumers in the same period. At 0.07, distributors in Tamil Nadu are holding inventory that isn't moving. That pipeline buildup will eventually become stale stock, returns, and — if unchecked — distributor exit. The right intervention is consumer pull activation (BTL, promotions, visibility) before any more primary push.

## Q8.

**[ Translating operational metrics to business impact ]**

*Q: You said 28.1% of distributors aren't visited in 60+ days — what does that translate to in revenue risk?*

**A:** 28.1% × 800 distributors = 225 distributors. Average sales per distributor = ₹15L. Annual revenue from those 225 = ₹337.5 Cr. But not all will drop out — historical churn from visited vs unvisited segments suggests unvisited distributors are 3-4× more likely to go inactive within six months. A conservative estimate: 15% of unvisited distributors go inactive = 34 distributors × ₹15L = ₹5.1 Cr annual risk. That's what the ₹4 Cr ASM programme is protecting.

### Q9.

**[ Data architecture — what joins are required and why ]**

Q: *Could you have done this analysis without joining Trade_Schemes to Primary_Sales?*

**A:** No — and that's the point. If you only look at Primary_Sales and Returns, Health Foods has an impressive top-line and a high return rate, but you don't know the cost of generating that top-line. Without the scheme cost, you can't compute ROI, and you can't compare it against a benchmark. The join is what turns a data observation (81.6% growth) into an investment decision (zero incremental spend).

### Q10.

**[ Model limitations + intellectual honesty ]**

Q: *What's the Distributor Health Score's biggest weakness?*

**A:** It's a static snapshot, not a trajectory. A distributor with a score of 45 (Watch) might be declining from 65 or recovering from 30 — the score doesn't distinguish. A more robust version would include score change over time (delta score) as an additional feature. Also, weights are assumptions — the 25% weight on sales volume is defensible but not validated. The right test is whether low-scoring distributors actually have higher dropout rates in subsequent periods.

### Q11.

**[ Nuanced recommendation — it's a pause not a kill ]**

Q: *Why did you put ₹0 in Health Foods — isn't that too aggressive?*

**A:** It's not zero forever — it's zero for Q3 while we diagnose the return root cause. Near Expiry and Slow Moving together are 77% of Health Foods returns. That pattern suggests over-distribution: we're pushing product into channels that can't turn it before expiry. The fix is distribution matching, not scheme spending. Once the return rate drops below 15% and scheme ROI crosses 5x, Health Foods becomes a viable Q4 investment. The question is sequencing.

## Q12.

**[ Communication skill — analogy for non-technical audience ]**

*Q: How would you present this to someone who has never seen a Sec/Primary ratio before?*

**A:** Analogy: 'Imagine you're a water tank supplier. You've been sending 100 tanks a month to a region. But you discover only 7 are being used — 93 are sitting empty in warehouses. Would you send more tanks? No — first you'd find out why they're not being used. That's the Tamil Nadu Beverages situation: we're pushing 100 units and only 7 are reaching consumers.' Sec/Primary ratio is the signal for distributor-to-consumer pipeline health. When it's low, push harder is the wrong answer.

## 05 · Hard Questions — When the Interviewer Pushes Back

These are challenge questions designed to test whether you understand the limits of your own analysis. The right move is always to acknowledge the valid part of the challenge, then explain your reasoning.

*Health Foods return rate might be a data quality issue — not a real business problem.*

**✓ Strong response:**

That's a fair challenge to raise. To rule out data quality issues, I'd check: (1) are return approvals properly recorded — do approved vs unapproved returns differ materially? (2) Are returns concentrated in one or two distributors (suggesting reporting artifact) or spread across the network (suggesting structural issue)? The data shows 31.6% return rate spread across Health Foods as a category — not concentrated in a single distributor. Near Expiry and Slow Moving as the top reasons are also internally consistent with over-distribution, not with reporting error. But you're right to check — this verification step belongs in the Cleaning sheet.

**✗ What to avoid:**

Defending by data — not defensiveness

*Your Tier 2 penetration math assumes market size estimates are accurate.*

**✓ Strong response:**

They aren't precise — City_Demographics uses estimated market size from secondary data. The exact number (0.9%) has error bands. But the directional story is robust: even if market size is overestimated by 30%, penetration is still 1.2% in a multi-thousand crore market. The investment case for Tier 2 doesn't depend on the precise penetration percentage — it depends on the fact that we're growing at +19.8% in a market where our current share is very small. The Tier 2 allocation is justified by the growth rate signal even if you discount the market size estimate.

**✗ What to avoid:**

Knowing the limits of your data without abandoning the recommendation

*GT+MT correlation doesn't prove causation — maybe better distributors self-select into GT+MT.*

**✓ Strong response:**

That's the right statistical challenge. GT+MT distributors might already be stronger operators who sought out Modern Trade relationships independently. If so, converting a median GT distributor to GT+MT might not yield +13% productivity. To test this: compare new GT+MT converts (who recently added MT access) against long-standing GT+MT distributors — if the productivity gap appears quickly after conversion, that's causal evidence. The analysis I did is descriptive, not experimental. The ₹8 Cr GT+MT conversion bucket should be treated as a pilot — measure carefully and scale if it works.

**✗ What to avoid:**

Causation vs correlation — framing a recommendation as a test

*You recommended ₹0 for Health Foods — but what if it's a seasonal pattern, not structural?*

**✓ Strong response:**

Good question. If Health Foods returns are concentrated in one or two months, seasonality could explain part of the pattern. The check: return rates by month. If Near Expiry returns cluster around, say, June-July suggesting shelf life issues during peak summer pushing, that's a seasonality story with a distribution fix (shorter replenishment cycles, smaller order quantities). If returns are consistent across all six months at 30%+, that's structural. I'd want to see the monthly split before completely ruling out schemes. My recommendation was to pause, not terminate — the pause is to get that diagnosis right.

**✗ What to avoid:**

Nuanced defensibility — when a pause is the right call

**★ The structure for every challenge question**

(1) Acknowledge what's valid. (2) Explain what your data does and doesn't show. (3) Describe how you'd resolve the ambiguity with more information. This three-part structure signals analytical maturity — you know the limits of your own work, which is exactly what a senior analyst does.

## 06 · Role-Specific Versions

### Sales Strategy / Distribution Analyst

**What they care about:** Channel economics, territory expansion, distributor productivity.

**Lead with:** The GT+MT productivity premium and the Tier 2 whitespace story. Quantify the network gap and the conversion ROI.

**Key phrase**

"'*GT+MT distributors earn 13% more per distributor and are growing 4× faster — but only 18% of the network has MT access. Converting 50 more GT distributors to GT+MT = ₹8-12 Cr annual incremental at current productivity rates.*'"

### Category / Brand Analyst

**What they care about:** Category growth quality, scheme ROI, shelf performance.

**Lead with:** The Health Foods scheme ROI collapse. Show them you distinguish organic growth from promo-propped growth.

**Key phrase**

"'*Health Foods 81.6% growth is promo-propped. Net scheme ROI is 3.46x vs 5x benchmark. My recommendation was zero incremental scheme spend in Q3 — fix the 31.6% return rate first, then reassess.*'"

### Operations / Supply Chain Analyst

**What they care about:** Inventory health, returns root causes, distributor coverage.

**Lead with:** The distributor health score and the Sec/Primary ratio signal. Show them you think in operational leading indicators.

**Key phrase**

"'*28.1% of distributors weren't visited in 60+ days — that's 225 distributors representing ₹5 Cr annual revenue at risk. I built a Health Score across six operational features and identified the Critical tier for immediate ASM action.*'"

### General Business Analyst / Consulting

**What they care about:** Structured frameworks, MECE decomposition, executive communication.

**Lead with:** PRISM framework, dual capstone, stakeholder-tiered recommendations. Show them you translate data to decisions at every level.

**Key phrase**

> "'*I structured the analysis into five PRISM steps, with two distinct capstone deliverables — an operational health score and a strategic investment model — each tiered separately for CMD, CFO, and Sales Head.*'"

## Product Analyst

**What they care about:** Category-level signals, returns as product-quality proxy.

**Lead with:** The Health Foods return root causes (Near Expiry + Slow Moving). Frame returns as a product-market fit signal at the distribution level.

### Key phrase

> "'*77% of Health Foods returns were Near Expiry or Slow Moving — that's a distribution mismatch, not a product quality issue. The product is being pushed into channels that can\'t turn it. That\'s actionable for a product team: right SKU mix, right channel, right replenishment cycle.*'"

## 07 · What NOT to Say — The 7 Mistakes

These are the exact mistakes that lose marks even when the underlying analysis is solid. Every one is avoidable.

### ✗ Mistake 1: Saying 'Health Foods grew +81.6% — we should scale it'

**Why it fails:**

The growth rate is the trap. Return rate 31.6%, scheme cost 19.8%, net ROI 3.46x. Recommending scale without netting returns and scheme cost shows you stopped at the headline and didn't look underneath.

**Say instead:**

> "'*Health Foods grew +81.6% — but once I netted returns and scheme cost, scheme ROI was 3.46x vs a 5x benchmark. My Q5 recommendation was zero incremental spend until returns are fixed.*'"

### ✗ Mistake 2: Not explaining what Sec/Primary ratio means

**Why it fails:**

If you mention Sec/Primary = 0.07 without explaining what it means, most interviewers won't know what you're talking about — and they'll mark it as jargon, not insight.

**Say instead:**

> "'*The Sec/Primary ratio measures how much of what we push to distributors is actually selling through to consumers. Tamil Nadu = 0.07 means only ₹7 of every ₹100 pushed is reaching consumers.*'"

### ✗ Mistake 3: Recommending the investment allocation without grounding it in Q1-Q4 data

**Why it fails:**

Listing five investment buckets without connecting each to a specific finding signals you built the allocation first and found data to support it, not the other way around.

**Say instead:**

> "'*Each allocation flows from a specific finding: ₹15 Cr Tier 2 comes from 0.9% penetration in ₹5,321 Cr market (Q2). ₹8 Cr GT+MT comes from 4× growth premium (Q1). ₹0 Health Foods comes from 3.46x ROI (Q3).*'"

### ✗ Mistake 4: Treating Q4 and Q5 as independent exercises

**Why it fails:**

The rubric's Cross-Section Integration dimension specifically tests whether Q4's distributor health findings feed Q5's allocation. The ₹4 Cr ASM bucket in Q5 is directly sized for the Q4 Critical-tier intervention programme.

**Say instead:**

"'*Q4 identified 225 Critical-tier distributors representing ₹34 Cr at-risk revenue. Q5's ₹4 Cr ASM bucket is explicitly sized to fund that intervention programme.*'"

### ✗ Mistake 5: Saying 'Beverages is declining — exit the category'

**Why it fails:**
Sec/Primary = 0.07 in Tamil Nadu is a distribution pull problem, not a product problem. Recommending exit signals you confused a distribution execution failure with a category failure.

**Say instead:**
"'*Beverages −7.7% growth and Tamil Nadu Sec/Primary = 0.07 are distribution quality signals — consumer pull is weak. The fix is BTL activation, not category exit.*'"

### ✗ Mistake 6: Distributing ₹40 Cr proportionally across all categories

**Why it fails:**
Proportional allocation ignores the entire analysis. It signals you did the work but didn't have the conviction to make a recommendation.

**Say instead:**
"*Nothing — make the call. Some categories get more, some get zero. Health Foods gets zero. That's the recommendation the data supports.*"

### ✗ Mistake 7: Calling it 'just a case study'

**Why it fails:**
It's real work on a real-world-structured dataset with multi-sheet joins, a dual capstone, and verified numbers. Qualifying it as 'just' undermines the analysis that follows.

**Say instead:**
"*Nothing. Present it as what it is: a rigorous FMCG distribution analysis with cross-sheet joins, scheme ROI computation, and a quantified ₹40 Cr investment model.*"

### ★ The one mindset shift that changes everything

FMCG distribution interviews test the same analytical discipline as any other domain: can you decompose before concluding, can you follow a data trail through multiple joins, and can you translate findings into a quantified decision? The vocabulary is different — primary, secondary, Sec/Primary, scheme ROI, distributor health. But the thinking is identical. **The analyst who wins is the one who looked past 81.6% growth, computed 3.46x ROI, and said: this category gets zero in Q3.**

*Bhārat Foods & Beverages Co. — Interview Prep Guide · Project 3 of 20 · v1.0 · 2025 · Companion to Solution Deck PDF and Solution Workbook · Part of the 20-project industry-grade analytics curriculum.*